

Summary & Opinion Writing Test

A timed reading-and-writing placement tool built for ERC Academy

Authored by Carlos Mercado · ERC Academy

This manual explains how to run the Summary & Opinion Writing Test webapp, what students see at each step, and how to collect a student's results once they finish. It is written for instructors and staff at ERC Academy, and can also be shared directly with students who need a walkthrough.

1. What this tool does

The webapp presents a short reading passage and asks the student to write two things: a short **summary** of the author's opinion, and the student's own **opinion** on the topic. The whole task is timed at 18 minutes, matching the format of a standard English placement writing task.

Three passages are built into the current version:

- **Passage 1** — Teenagers and part-time jobs
- **Passage 2** — Whether zoos are good for animals
- **Passage 3** — Whether computers have made life better

Word count requirements

Task	Requirement	What the student sees
Summary	25–50 words	A live word count that turns green in range, red outside it
Opinion	50+ words minimum	The same live word count and colour feedback
Both tasks	18 minutes total	A countdown timer that turns red under 2 minutes left

2. Starting a test

- 1 Open the webapp**
Open the `writing_test.html` file in any modern browser (Chrome, Safari, Edge). No installation, login, or internet connection is required to run the test itself.
- 2 Enter the student's name**
On the opening screen, type the student's full name into the name field. This name is used to label the results and cannot be left blank.

3

Choose a passage

Select one of the three passage cards. The selected card is outlined and its dot fills in to confirm the choice.

4

Select "Begin test"

The button is greyed out until both a name and a passage are set. Selecting it starts the 18-minute timer immediately — the timer cannot be paused once it begins, so make sure the student is ready.

3. Taking the test

The test screen is split into two halves. The passage stays on the left in its own scrolling panel, and the writing area is on the right — this way the student can always refer back to the text while they write.

On the right-hand side

- Two "Summary" and "Opinion" tabs at the top jump straight to either box.
- Each box has its own header bar showing a live word count.
- A short hint line under each box states how many words are still needed, or confirms the length is good.

The timer

The countdown sits in the top-right of the header, with a thin progress bar beneath it. It turns red once under two minutes remain. If time runs out before the student submits, the test **submits automatically** with whatever has been written so far.

4. Submitting the test

Selecting "Submit test" checks both boxes against the word count requirements.

- If both boxes meet the minimum word counts, the test submits right away.
- If either box is short, a warning banner appears in the footer explaining what's missing, with a choice to "Keep writing" or "Submit anyway."

Note

Submitting is final. Once a test is submitted, the timer stops and the student is moved to the results screen — there is no way to go back and continue writing.

5. Collecting the results

After submission, the results screen shows the student's name, chosen passage, time used, and both pieces of writing with their word counts. From here there are three ways to save or send the results:

A Email results to instructor

Opens a new browser tab with a Gmail message already addressed to **ercerc.academianic@gmail.com**, with the subject and full results pre-filled in the body. The student (or instructor) only needs to select Send. This requires being signed into a Gmail account in that browser tab.

B Download results (.txt)

Saves a plain text file of the results to the device. Use this if the computer is not signed into Gmail, or if results need to be attached to a different email provider.

C Print / save as PDF

Opens the browser's print dialog with a clean, printable version of the results (the buttons and notes are hidden automatically). Choose "Save as PDF" in the print dialog to keep a PDF copy instead of printing on paper.

Recommended workflow

Have the student select "Email results to instructor" as the primary method. If that tab doesn't open a pre-filled message (for example, no Gmail account is signed in on that device), fall back to "Download results" and email the file manually.

6. Troubleshooting

Issue	What to do
"Begin test" stays greyed out	Check that a name has been typed AND a passage card is selected — both are required.
"Submit test" seems to do nothing	Look at the footer — a warning banner likely appeared asking to confirm submission because a box is under the word minimum.
Email button opens a blank or sign-in page	The browser isn't signed into a Gmail account. Sign in, or use "Download results" instead.
Timer reached zero	This is expected behaviour — the test auto-submits with whatever was written, exactly like a real placement test.
Need to test again	Refresh the page to return to the name and passage selection screen.